Psychology and behavior

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: The mind and behavior (188 words)

Psychology tries to explain why people think, feel and act as they do. Early researchers studied **perception**: how the brain makes sense of sights and sounds. A sudden **stimulus**, such as a loud noise, produces an immediate **reaction**, often before conscious thought, and a great deal of everyday **behavior** is **subconscious**. A hasty **impulse** may lead to a decision that was effectively **unconscious**.

Several factors shape **personality**. A person's **attitude** and key **trait** qualities develop through experience, and our social surroundings can **shape the way we think**: many people **conform** to group norms to avoid standing out, and parents and friends **influence** choices throughout life. High **self-esteem** helps people face challenges, whereas chronic **anxiety** can damage health.

Memory, too, is part of the story. A strong **memory** helps learning, and any strong **emotion** makes an event easier to recall. Behavior can be shaped by **reinforcement**: praise or reward makes a habit more likely to be repeated, and **motivation** often increases when goals are clear. Above all, **resilience** and the ability to **bounce back from** failure are better predictors of long-term success than **cognitive** ability alone, though **cognitive** skills also matter.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
shape the way we think	affect our ideas
bounce back from	recover after
cognitive	connected with thinking

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
cognitive	adj	related to thinking and understanding	*Cognitive skills develop in childhood.*
perception	n	the way you see or understand things	*Our perception of time changes with age.*
memory	n	the ability to remember	*Sleep improves memory.*
emotion	n	a strong feeling	*Fear is a basic emotion.*
motivation	n	the reason for doing something	*Rewards can increase motivation.*
behavior	n	the way a person acts	*Behavior is shaped by environment.*
stimulus	n	something that causes a reaction	*A loud noise is a strong stimulus.*

subconscious	adj	happening without your knowing	*Many habits are subconscious.*
anxiety	n	worry or fear about the future	*Exams cause anxiety in many students.*
personality	n	the character of a person	*Her personality is cheerful.*
trait	n	a quality of a person's character	*Honesty is a valued trait.*
attitude	n	a way of thinking about something	*A positive attitude helps learning.*
conform	v	to behave as others do	*Teenagers often conform to the group.*
influence	v	to affect how someone thinks or acts	*Parents influence a child's choices.*
reaction	n	a response to something	*His reaction was immediate.*
unconscious	adj	not aware	*The decision was unconscious.*
impulse	n	a sudden strong wish to do something	*He bought it on impulse.*
self-esteem	n	belief in your own value	*Praise builds self-esteem.*
reinforce	v	to strengthen a habit by a reward	*Praise reinforces good behavior.*
resilience	n	the ability to recover from difficulty	*Resilience helps people cope with failure.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
species	n	a kind of living thing
predator	n	an animal that hunts others
prey	n	an animal that is hunted
migrate	v	to travel to another region each year
hibernate	v	to sleep through the winter
offspring	n	the young of an animal
evolution	n	slow change in living things over time
adapt	v	to change to live in new conditions
nocturnal	adj	active at night
herbivore	n	an animal that eats plants

Practice: fill the gaps

conform · trait · memory · influence · reinforce · attitude · reaction · anxiety

1. Teenagers often _____ to the group.
2. Honesty is a valued _____.

3. Sleep improves _____.
4. Parents _____ a child's choices.
5. Praise _____ good behavior.
6. A positive _____ helps learning.
7. His _____ was immediate.
8. Exams cause _____ in many students.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

aggression (n): angry, violent behavior
altruism (n): caring about others' welfare
bias (n): an unfair preference
bond (n): an emotional link
bullying (n): repeated unkind behavior
conscious (adj): aware
conditioning (n): learning through repeated experience
curiosity (n): a desire to know
depression (n): a state of deep sadness
development (n): growth and change
disposition (n): a person's natural character
empathy (n): understanding others' feelings
habit (n): a regular practice
identity (n): who a person is
imitation (n): copying others
inhibition (n): a feeling that stops you acting freely
instinctive (adj): natural, not learned
introvert (n): a quiet, inward-looking person
extrovert (n): an outgoing person
intelligence (n): the ability to learn and understand
nature (n): inborn qualities
nurture (n): the effect of upbringing
obsession (n): a thought you cannot stop
phobia (n): a strong fear
reflex (n): an automatic reaction
self-control (n): the ability to control yourself
social skills (n): the ability to deal with others
subjective (adj): based on personal feelings
therapy (n): treatment for mental problems

Answers

1. conform (conform)
2. trait (trait)
3. memory (memory)
4. influence (influence)
5. reinforces (reinforce)
6. attitude (attitude)
7. reaction (reaction)
8. anxiety (anxiety)